



SANYO Eneloop solar light

in rechargeable battery," says Hiroaki Shirai, head of global sales and marketing, Sanyo.

"Sanyo Eneloop range is known for its long-lasting battery. Eneloop solar light can be used for rooms and as a beam for flashlight use. Depending on the amount of light used, it will release around 9 to 50 hours of light. What's more, its USB port can be used for charging cellphones and other gadgets," says Kunal Jivrajka, executive director, JSK Marketing. Eneloop solar light is available from JSK Marketing for Rs 13,500.

Sanyo does develop some of the most stunning green gadgets, but unfortunately it limits the sales of these products to Japan and Singapore. Not this time though, because the company is planning to add a portable solar generator and neck warmer to its Eneloop line in other parts of Asia as well.

Solar Store has a variety of solar gadgets, ranging from solar torch-cum-radio-cum-mobile charger to LED battery tester to solar battery charger with meter to solar AM/FM radio. "The solar torch with three LEDs has three-way charging facility—AC, solar panel and dynamo. It is priced at Rs

2500. The solar-powered LED key-chain torch flashlight has built-in solar panel, giving relief to the user from changing batteries or bulbs. Just put this flashlight under the sun and it'll be ready to go wherever required. This waterproof gadget costs Rs 850," states Yogi Tripathi, proprietor, Solar Store. "Demand for these gadgets is picking up," he adds.

Some imported solar gadgets can be bought online. One example is the solar-powered electric shaver, which will prove handy for someone who is always on the move. It can also be charged by AC, if needed. The shaver uses an inbuilt high-technique solar panel.

There are solar-driven headphones as well, which are bound to impress the teenagers. The Bluetooth-connected Q-sound (quantum sound) headphone set has flexible solar-powered panels, wireless technology and rotating earpieces. One hour in the sun allows three hours of power. The headphones can run up to 40 hours when fully charged.

South Korea's LG Display has developed a solar panel for an e-book reader. The panel is 10 cm in width and length and has been combined with a

Sony electronic book reader. Exposure to sunlight for four to five hours provides enough power to run the e-book reader for a day, claims LG. However, the e-reader will be commercially available only by 2012.

Canon's solar calculator is fully solar-powered, making it usable everywhere. Another smart option is a solar-powered air purifier. You can place it at your kitchen window or in your car. It is a far better option than an air freshener as many are allergic to strong smells.

Some domestic manufacturers are also venturing into this space as they feel solar energy would be in great demand in the years to come. Waaree Energies, one of India's largest producers of PV modules, imports solar gadgets from China and Germany. "We have about 25 such gadgets with which we bundle our solar panels. These gadgets include solar torches, solar mobile chargers, solar fan caps, solar name plate displays, solar key chains, etc. The prices range from Rs 100 to Rs 10,000," says Uday Dharja, vice president, Waaree Energies. "Our solar mobile charger can charge MP3 players, musical instruments, cameras, etc. These gizmos also work as stored power-backup items that can be used anywhere and at any time," he adds. They also come with adaptors for various phone types and makes.

Radha Energy Cell manufactures many such solar gadgets. Says Rajesh Soni, director, Radha Energy Cell, "Our solar radio, battery charger, cool cap and torch are very well received by our customers. The solar radio charged for one hour can run for five hours, and the torch can run for six hours if fully charged. Demand for these products is picking up in India but will take some more time to become comparable with the international countries," adds Soni.

So go for an eco-friendly gift this Valentine's Day and love the planet too! ●

*The author is a senior assistant editor at EYF*